Adaptability questions

Design Gurus

Three answers to Amazon questions, in the same format as the earlier chapter. Each one names the principles it evidences, so you can see how a single story covers more than one.

Question 1: Tell me about a time you had to make a decision without all the data you wanted.

Principles this evidences: Bias for Action, Are Right A Lot, Dive Deep.

Situation: "Our checkout error rate went from about 0.2 percent to 3 percent over a weekend. Roughly 1,400 orders a day were failing. Nothing had been deployed on the Friday, so there was no obvious cause."

Task: "I was on call. A full investigation would have taken two or three days. Every day of waiting cost about 1,400 orders, so waiting for certainty was itself a decision."

Action: "I spent the first two hours narrowing rather than fixing. The failures were all on one payment provider, and all on cards issued outside our main market, which was about 6 percent of traffic. I could not prove why, but the pattern was strong enough to act on. I routed that 6 percent to our secondary provider, because I knew that change was reversible in one configuration edit. Then I kept investigating with the error rate back down. Two days later the provider confirmed a certificate change on their side."

Result: "The error rate returned to 0.2 percent within about forty minutes of the reroute. We lost roughly 1,400 orders in total instead of the 4,000 we would have lost waiting for proof. I now separate reversible decisions from irreversible ones before I decide how much evidence I need. Rerouting was reversible, so two hours of evidence was enough."

Follow-up you should expect: "What would you have done if the reroute had made it worse?"

Why they ask: Bias for Action is easy to confuse with recklessness. They want to know whether you had considered the downside before you moved.

How to answer it: "I watched it for fifteen minutes before I stepped away from the screen. Reverting was one configuration change and I had it ready. That is why I picked that action over the other candidate, which was blocking those cards entirely. Blocking would have stopped the errors too, but undoing it needed a deploy."

Question 2: Tell me about a time you disagreed with your manager.

Principles this evidences: Have Backbone Disagree and Commit, Earn Trust, Deliver Results.

Situation: "My manager wanted to rewrite our reporting service in a new framework, over

about a quarter. I thought the reporting service was not our real problem. Our support tickets were mostly about data being out of date, not about the service."

Task: "I was the senior engineer on the team, and he had already told his own manager it was the plan. Disagreeing after that point is harder. I had one week before the work was scheduled to start."

Action: "I did not argue about the framework. I went and got the number instead. I read the last 200 support tickets and sorted them by cause. Eleven were about the service being slow. A hundred and forty were about data being hours out of date. I brought him one page with that split, and a proposal. Two weeks on the data pipeline first, then decide about the rewrite with the ticket numbers in front of us. I said plainly that I thought the rewrite was the wrong order, not the wrong idea."

Result: "He agreed to the two weeks. The pipeline work cut data lag from about four hours to under fifteen minutes. Reporting tickets fell by roughly 70 percent over the following month. We never did the rewrite, and he was the one who cancelled it. What made this work was disagreeing with evidence rather than with judgment. If he had still chosen the rewrite, I would have done it properly, because the decision was his to make."

Follow-up you should expect: "You said you would have committed. How do you actually do that when you think it is wrong?"

Why they ask: The second half of that principle is the half candidates skip. Anyone can describe disagreeing.

How to answer it: "I write down what I expect to happen and when we should check. Then I stop arguing. Having it written means I do not keep reopening it in meetings, which is the part that damages a team. I have done this twice. Once I was right, and we changed course three months later with no argument, because the prediction was already on paper. Once I was wrong, and knowing that has made me slower to be certain."

Question 3: Tell me about a time you failed.

Principles this evidences: Earn Trust, Learn and Be Curious, Ownership.

Situation: "I led a migration of our search index to a new provider. I estimated six weeks. It took fourteen, and for three of those weeks search results were noticeably worse for customers."

Task: "I had made the estimate, and I had told the product team they could plan a launch around it. So the miss was mine, and it had cost somebody else their plan as well."

Action: "The cause was that I tested against a copy of production data that was six months old. Our newer records used a field the old provider accepted and the new one rejected, which was about 4 percent of documents. I found it in week five, after we had already switched. I told the product lead the same day, before I had a fix, because her launch depended on it. Then I stopped the rollout and moved the affected traffic back. I rebuilt the migration to run both providers side by side, so I could compare results rather than trust them."

Result: "We finished in week fourteen with no further customer impact, and the side-by-side comparison caught two more mismatches before customers saw them. The launch moved by five weeks, which was real damage. What I changed is that I no longer test a migration against a sample. I test against a full copy, and I run both systems together before switching. I have done two migrations since on that pattern, and both landed inside the estimate."

Follow-up you should expect: "You said you told the product lead before you had a fix. Why?"

Why they ask: Earn Trust is largely about what you do with bad news, and the timing of the disclosure is the answer.

How to answer it: "Because her decision depended on it and mine did not. Staying quiet would not have made the fix faster, and every day she planned around a date I knew was wrong was a day wasted. She moved the launch that week instead of three weeks later. The cost of telling her early was one uncomfortable conversation. The cost of telling her late would have been her credibility as well as mine."